Install OVF Server Explorer

Version 1.0.5, for KNIME on Windows, Linux and macOS. Adds a Server Explorer tab next to KNIME Explorer. This is a third-party plugin, not a KNIME product.

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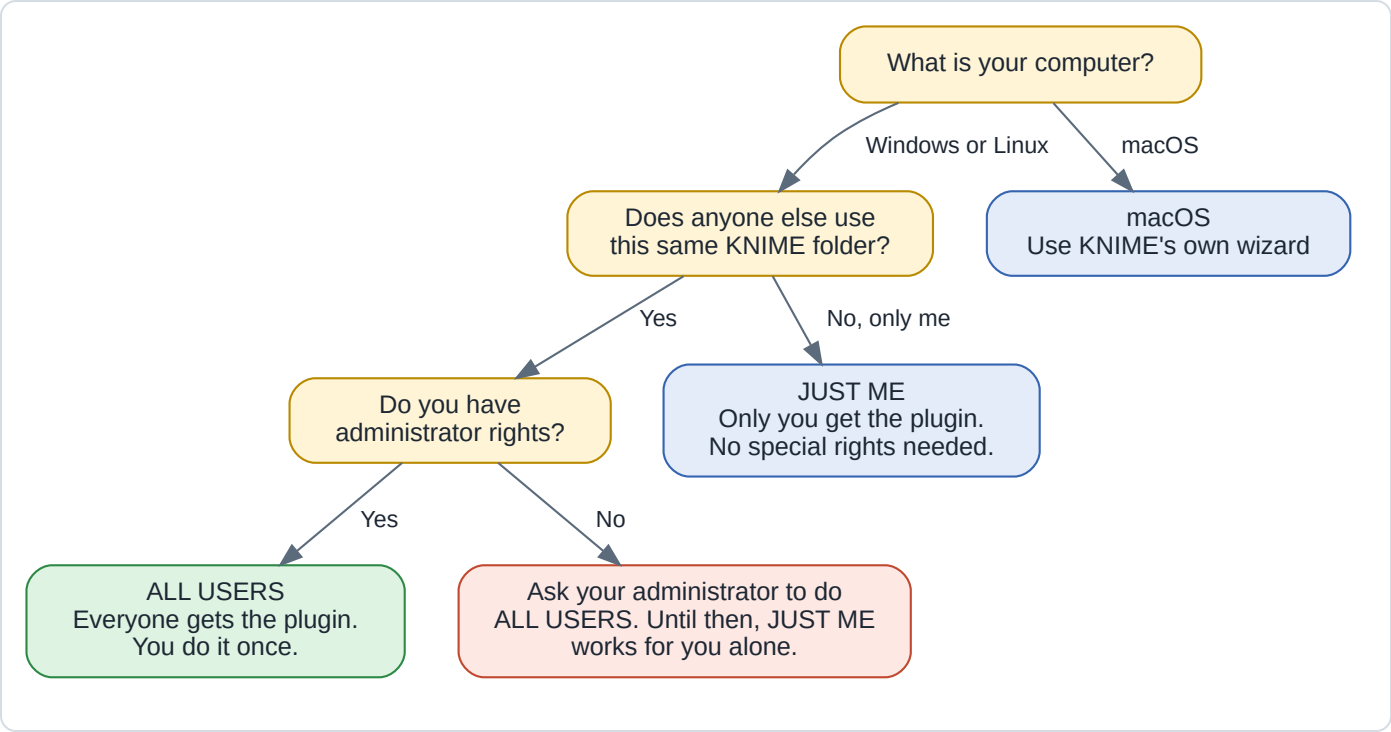
1. Get the right download

Find your KNIME version under **Help › About KNIME**, then download the installer for it. There are two builds, and the installer refuses the wrong one.

Your KNIME	Installer (Windows, Linux)	Update-site address (macOS, or KNIME's wizard)
5.x	5.x installer zip	`https://shinwachi.github.io/ovf-updates/5x/`
4.1 or 4.2	4.1.x installer zip	`https://shinwachi.github.io/ovf-updates/4.1.x/`

No internet on the KNIME computer? Copy the zip over. It has everything inside. All files are on the downloads page.

2. Choose how to install

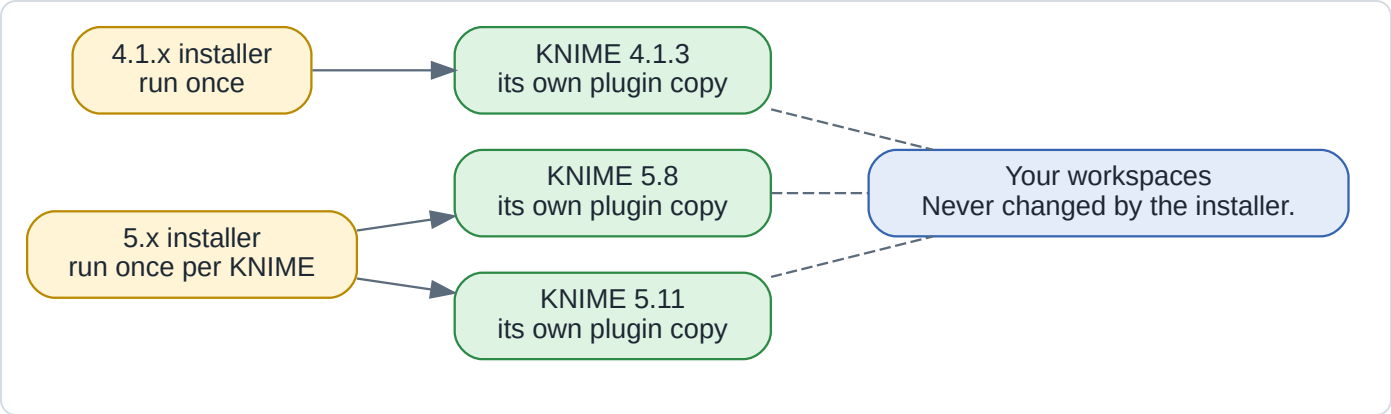


All users is the better choice when people share one KNIME: there is one copy to look after, and it keeps working when an administrator changes KNIME. **Just me** needs no rights, but each person installs and updates their own copy, and it stops loading if an administrator later changes KNIME (section 8 has the fix).

If you have several KNIME versions

The installer offers two ways to choose, and changes only the KNIME you choose. Run it once for each KNIME that should have the plugin, using the matching zip.

- **Scan** lists every KNIME it finds, with its version and whether it already has the plugin. Pick one by number. It looks in the usual places, so a KNIME somewhere unusual may not be listed.
- **File picker** lets you select `knime.exe` (Windows) or `knime` (Linux) yourself. On Linux it needs a desktop, and `zenity` or `kdialog`. If no picker can open, for example over SSH, you can type the folder instead.




```
KNIME folders on this machine:
  1) C:\Program Files\knime_4.1.3
     KNIME 4.1.3, needs the 4.1.x installer
  2) C:\Program Files\knime_5.8.1
     KNIME 5.8.1, installed for you (1.0.5)
  3) C:\Tools\KNIME Analytics
     KNIME 5.8.1, not installed
Which KNIME? Type a number, p for a file picker, or a folder path:
```

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3. Windows

All users You need administrator rights

1
Close KNIME, and ask anyone else using it to close it too. If someone can't, you can still install: see section 10.

→

2
Extract the zip. Right-click it › **Extract All...** Running from inside the zip doesn't work.

→

3
In the extracted folder, right-click `install-ovf.cmd` › **Run as administrator**.

→

4
Choose your KNIME: type `1` to scan and pick from a list, or `2` for a file picker. Then type `1` for who gets it.

→

5
Restart KNIME. Do this for everyone using it.

Then set the recommended folder permissions, so ordinary users can't change KNIME by accident. In an administrator Command Prompt, from the extracted folder:

```
install-ovf.cmd -Knime "C:\Program Files\KNIME" -Mode admin -ApplyPermissions
```

Just me No special rights needed

1 **Close KNIME.** → **2** **Extract the zip.** Right-click it › **Extract All...** → **3** In the extracted folder, **double-click** `install-ovf.cmd`. → **4** **Choose your KNIME:** type `1` to scan and pick from a list, or `2` for a file picker. Then type `2` for who gets it. → **5** **Restart KNIME.**

The KNIME folder is the one holding `knime.exe`. To find it, right-click the KNIME shortcut › **Open file location**.

> If Windows warns about a downloaded file, choose **More info › Run anyway**. If your organization's policy blocks the script, ask your administrator: they need to allow or sign `install-ovf.ps1`.

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4. Linux

All users You need sudo

1 **Close KNIME**, and ask anyone else using it to close it too. If someone can't, you can still install: see section 10. → **2** **Extract the zip** into a new folder, then go there. → **3** **Run** `sudo ./install-ovf.sh` → **4** **Choose your KNIME:** type `1` to scan and pick from a list, or `2` for a file picker. Then type `1` for who gets it. → **5** **Restart KNIME.** Do this for everyone using it.

```
unzip ovf-serverconnector-5.x-1.0.5-installer.zip -d ovf-installer
cd ovf-installer
sudo ./install-ovf.sh --knime /opt/knime --mode admin --apply-permissions
```

This one command also sets the recommended folder permissions. Change `5.x` to `4.1.x` and `/opt/knime` to your KNIME folder as needed.

Just me No special rights needed

1 **Close KNIME.** → **2** **Extract the zip** into a new folder, then go there. → **3** **Run** `./install-ovf.sh` without sudo. → **4** **Choose your KNIME:** type `1` to scan and pick from a list, or `2` for a file picker. Then type `2` for who gets it. → **5** **Restart KNIME.**

The KNIME folder is the one holding the `knime` program, `knime.ini` and `plugins`.

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5. macOS

> **Not tested on macOS.** The plugin has no Windows- or Linux-specific code, so it's expected to work, but nobody has confirmed it. The installer scripts don't support macOS, so use KNIME's own wizard.

1 **Open the wizard:** File › **Install KNIME Extensions...** In KNIME 5's Modern UI: **Menu › Install extensions**. → **2** Click **Add...**, then paste the update-site address from section 1 into **Location**. Click **Add**. → **3** Tick **OVF Server Explorer**, click **Next**, accept the license, click **Finish**. → **4** KNIME warns that the plugin is unsigned. Choose **Install anyway**. → **5** **Restart KNIME** when asked.

The wizard also works on Windows and Linux, but it can't ask who the plugin is for. It installs for everyone if you can write to the KNIME folder, and otherwise for you alone.

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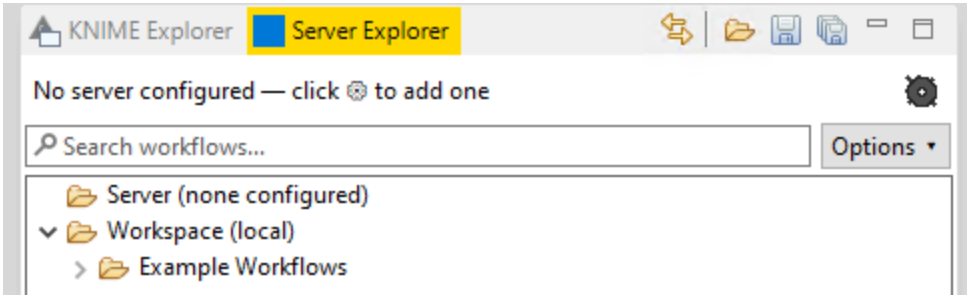
6. Check that it worked

> **KNIME 5:** the tab is only in the classic user interface. If KNIME opens in the Modern UI (a dark bar with Home, Preferences and Menu at the top), click **Menu › Switch to classic user interface**. KNIME reopens with the tab. To go back, click **Open KNIME Modern UI** at the top right.

When the installer succeeds, it prints a line like one of these:

```
Installed for everyone: C:\Program Files\KNIME\plugins\org.ovf.serverconnector_1.0.5.413.jar
Installed:
C:\Users\you\.eclipse\1637230351_win32_win32_x86_64\plugins\org.ovf.serverconnector_1.0.5.413.jar

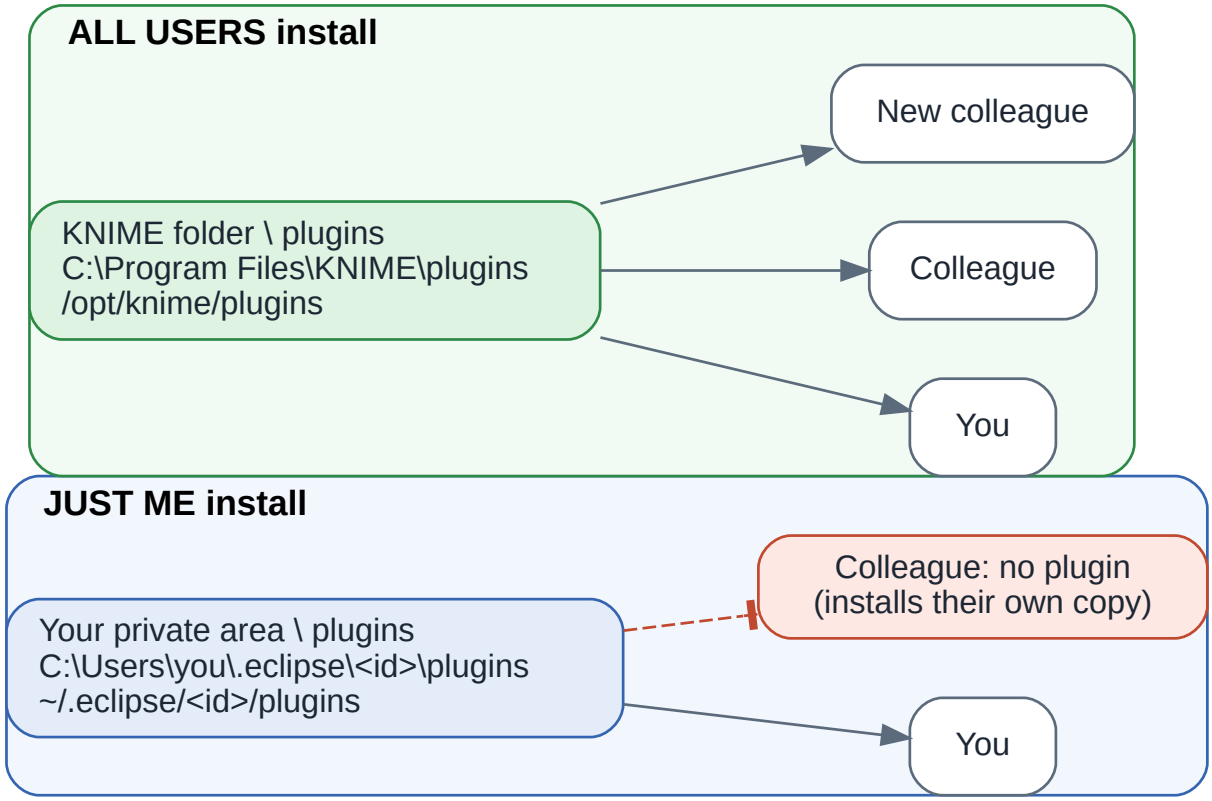
Restart KNIME. The Server Explorer tab appears next to KNIME Explorer.
```



The Server Explorer tab, next to KNIME Explorer, after clicking it. This shows a new install with no server set up yet.

To connect to a server, click the gear icon in the tab, or go to **File › Preferences › Server Connector › Servers**. The **Server Connector** page also says who has the plugin and where its files are.

7. Where the files go, and permissions



What	Where	Who should have access
KNIME folder	`C:\Program Files\KNIME` `/opt/knime`	Administrators: full control. Everyone else: read and execute only, on all files inside.
Private area, one per person	`C:\Users\you\.eclipse\<id>` `~/.eclipse/<id>`	Only that person. KNIME creates it. Don't change or share it.
Workspace, one per person	`C:\Users\you\knime-workspace` `~/knime-workspace`	Only that person. Two people can't have one workspace open at once.

Workspaces need nothing

The installer never asks for a workspace and never changes one, so an administrator can install for all users without touching anyone's. The first time a workspace opens in a KNIME with the plugin, the plugin adds its own tab, including in workspaces that already have a saved layout.

- **Your server list is saved in the workspace.** A new workspace starts with no servers, so add them again there.
- **A KNIME without the plugin can still open the workspace.** It shows a red **Server Explorer (needs OVF plugin)** tab. Nothing is lost: the tab works again next time you use a KNIME with the plugin.

Check a KNIME

To see this report for your own computer without changing anything:

```
install-ovf.cmd -Knime "C:\Program Files\KNIME" -Check
./install-ovf.sh --knime /opt/knime --check
```

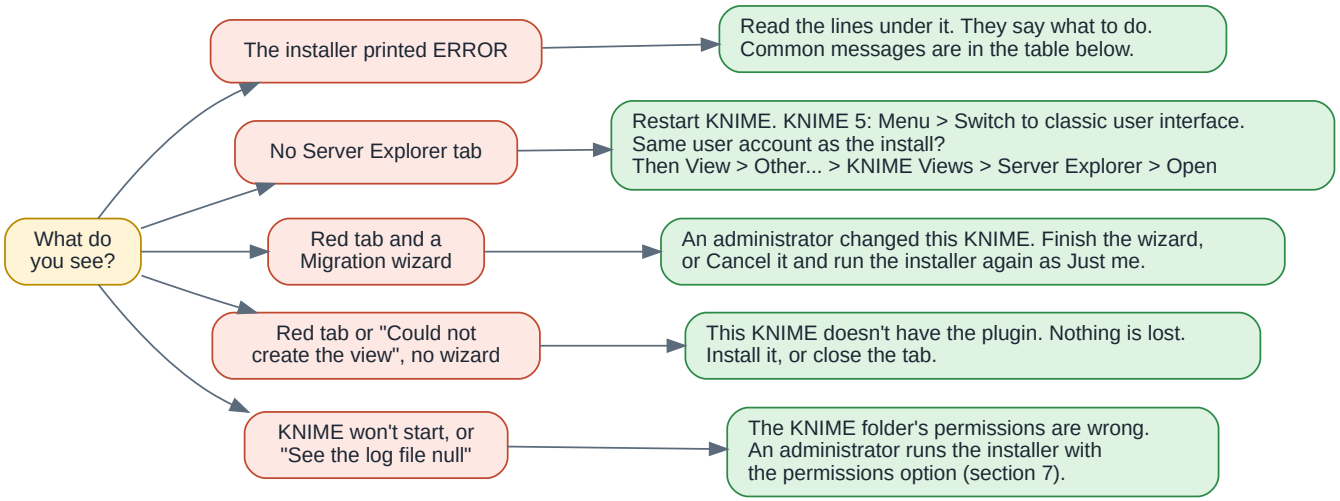
Two permission settings cause most problems:

- **Users can create files but not change them.** This is the Windows default if KNIME is unzipped into a folder under `C:\` instead of Program Files. Installs fail, nodes go missing, and the second person's KNIME may not start.
- **Everyone has full control.** One user can uninstall the plugin for everybody.

An administrator can fix both with the permissions option:

```
install-ovf.cmd -Knime "C:\KNIME" -Mode admin -ApplyPermissions
sudo ./install-ovf.sh --knime /opt/knime --mode admin --apply-permissions
```

8. If something goes wrong



The installer's messages usually name the cause. These are the common ones:

It says	What to do
this installer is for KNIME 4.x but ... is KNIME 5.x	You have the wrong zip. Download the other one (section 1).
... is missing, and it belongs to another extension	Another extension is damaged, not this plugin. Ask an administrator to restore or remove that extension, or to install this plugin for all users.
The plugin was installed for everyone, but its jar is gone	An administrator runs the all-users install again.
can create files in it but can't change KNIME's own files	An administrator fixes the permissions (section 7).
another install was probably running	Wait for it to finish, then run the installer again.
can't be read ... It may be damaged	Download the installer zip again.
knime.ini sets KNIME's configuration	Take the `-configuration` lines out of `knime.ini`, install, then put them back. A Just me install handles this by itself.

can't create a temporary file	Free some space there, or point `TEMP` (Windows) or `TMPDIR` (Linux) at a folder you can write to.

If the message doesn't help, send your administrator the `Full log` file named at the end of the installer's output.

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9. Update or remove

Update: download the new zip and run the installer the same way you did the first time. It replaces the old version. With Just me, each person does this for themselves. Along the way you may see `Cannot complete the install because of a conflicting dependency`, followed by `Replacing the installed version...` That is normal.

> If you installed Just me and an administrator then installs for all users, your own old copy keeps loading. Run the installer as Just me once to bring it up to date.

Remove: close KNIME, then use the same mode you installed with. For an all-users change, ask everyone else to close it too (section 10).

```
install-ovf.cmd -Knime "C:\Program Files\KNIME" -Mode admin -Uninstall    (or -Mode user)
./install-ovf.sh --knime /opt/knime --mode admin --uninstall              (or --mode user)
```

If you used the wizard: **Help › About KNIME › Installation Details**, select **OVF Server Explorer**, click **Uninstall...**

If a tab then shows an error, close it. Your workflows aren't affected.

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10. If people still have KNIME open

This is about `All users` installs, updates and removals. Asking everyone to close KNIME first is the safest way, but it isn't required. **You can install anyway and ask people to restart.** The installer lets you do this.

Why the steps ask people to close KNIME

KNIME reads its list of plugins only when it starts. A KNIME that is already open doesn't notice an install. It keeps using the version it started with, and the jar file for that version, until it restarts. Closing KNIME first avoids the problems in the table below, and makes sure everyone is on the new version straight away.

What happens if someone doesn't close it

While KNIME is open, you...	What that person sees	What to do
Install for the first time	KNIME carries on, without the tab.	Restart. The tab appears.
Update to a new version	KNIME carries on with the old version, and the plugin keeps working. The old jar stays on disk.	Restart to get the new version.
Change it again before they restart: a second update, a reinstall, or a removal	This change can delete the old jar they're still using. The tab may look normal, but a part of the plugin they haven't used yet can fail. For example, the server settings page shows `Unable to create the selected preference page`. KNIME itself stays open.	Restart. This clears the error. To avoid it, get everyone restarted before you change anything again.
Remove the plugin	KNIME carries on. After a restart, the tab shows `Could not create the view`.	Close that tab.
Someone starts KNIME during the install, which takes a few seconds	In the one try made, KNIME started normally, without the new version.	Restart.

No KNIME closed or lost its window in any of these tests. Save your work and restart if you see an error in the plugin. What the tests didn't cover is a workflow running, or one opened from a server with unsaved changes, at the moment the jar is deleted.

Install anyway and ask people to restart

1
Run the installer as usual. If KNIME is running, it says `KNIME appears to be running` and asks `Continue anyway?`

→

2
Type `y`. Typing anything else stops and changes nothing. With `--yes` or `-Yes`, it continues without asking.

→

3
Ask everyone to save their work and restart KNIME. You have to tell them yourself: nothing inside KNIME says a new version is waiting.

→

4
Check who still has it open (commands below), and wait for them before you change anything again.

```
Windows, in an administrator PowerShell:
  Get-Process knime -IncludeUserName | Select-Object UserName, Id

Linux:
  ps -eo user,args | grep '[/]plugins/org.knime.binary.jre' | cut -c1-70
```

> **The installer's warning only covers this computer.** It can't see KNIME running on other computers from a shared network folder. On Windows it also reacts to KNIME running from any folder, not just the one you chose.

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11. What this was tested on

Platform	KNIME	Result
Linux	4.1.3	All users and Just me: install, update from 1.0.3 and 1.0.4, remove. Tab checked.
Linux	5.8.1	All users and Just me: install, update from 1.0.3 and 1.0.4. Tab checked in the classic UI.
Windows Server 2022	4.1.3	All users and Just me: install, remove, permissions. Tab checked.

Windows Server 2022	5.8.1	All users and Just me: install, remove, permissions. Tab checked in the classic UI. The test machine couldn't run the Modern UI, with or without the plugin.
Linux	4.1.3 and three copies of 5.8.1	Scan and file picker (zenity), including cancelling and wrong selections. Only the chosen KNIME changed. Workspaces tested as described in section 7.
Windows Server 2022	Seven 4.1.3 folders and two 5.8.1	Scan and file picker. Only the chosen KNIME changed. Update from 1.0.4 on 5.8.1, tab checked on 4.1.3 and 5.8.1.
Linux and Windows Server 2022	4.1.3 and 5.8.1	All-users update from 1.0.4 to 1.0.5 and removal, with two other people's KNIME open. Deleting a jar in use made the settings page fail on 4.1.3, on both systems. On 5.8.1 it kept working, because that jar happened to still be open, so don't count on this. A second update, tested on Linux with nobody's KNIME open, deleted the older jar too.
Any	4.2.3	The 4.1.x plugin installs. The 1.0.5 installer wasn't tried on it.

Not tested: macOS, Windows 10 and 11, other KNIME versions, one workspace used in both KNIME 4 and KNIME 5, domain Group Policy, antivirus software, roaming profiles, and KNIME on a remote file server.

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12. Exactly what changes on disk

This section is for administrators and anyone curious. It lists what the plugin adds, how KNIME learns about it, and where its settings are kept. `<ver>` is the version, such as `1.0.5` or `1.0.5.413`. Paths use `/`, and on Windows the same paths apply with `\`.

How KNIME finds the plugin

The program is one file, a jar. KNIME doesn't scan for new jars: at startup it loads the plugins named in a list called `bundles.info`. **Adding one line to that list is what registers the plugin.** The jar then tells KNIME about the Server Explorer view, the settings pages and a startup step that adds the tab.

All users Inside the KNIME folder

File, under the KNIME folder	What changes
`plugins/org.ovf.serverconnector_<ver>.jar`	**The program.** New file.
`features/org.ovf.serverconnector.feature_<ver>/feature.xml`	New file. Names the plugin as an installable item.
`configuration/org.eclipse.equinox.simpleconfigurator/bundles.info`	**The registration.** One line added, shown below.
`artifacts.xml`	Two records added: the jar and the feature. Its timestamp and count change too.
`p2/org.eclipse.equinox.p2.engine/profileRegistry/KNIMEProfile.profile/`	New `*.profile.gz` files: KNIME's installer's record of what is installed. This is why the plugin appears in **Installation Details**.
`configuration/config.ini`	Only the date in its comment line changes.
Other files in `configuration/` and `p2/`	KNIME's own caches and logs, refreshed because its installer ran. These hold no plugin settings you need to manage.

The line added to `bundles.info`. The path is relative to the KNIME folder:

```
org.ovf.serverconnector,1.0.5,plugins/org.ovf.serverconnector_1.0.5.jar,4,false
```

The last two values are the plugin's start level and whether KNIME starts it straight away. Don't edit this file by hand. Use the installer, so that it stays in step with KNIME's installer records.

Just me In your private area

Nothing in the KNIME folder changes. Everything goes in your private area, one folder per KNIME:

```
Windows:  C:\Users\you\.eclipse\<id>\
Linux:    ~/.eclipse/<id>/

<id> looks like one of these, and the number comes from the KNIME folder's path:
  1877637008_linux_gtk_x86_64                              (KNIME 4)
  org.eclipse.platform_4.31.0_1878567254_linux_gtk_x86_64     (KNIME 5)
```

File, under the private area	What changes
`plugins/org.ovf.serverconnector_<ver>.jar`	**The program.** New file.
`features/org.ovf.serverconnector.feature_<ver>/feature.xml`	New file.
`configuration/org.eclipse.equinox.simpleconfigurator/bundles.info`	**The registration.** Your own copy of KNIME's whole list, plus the plugin's line.
`artifacts.xml`, `configuration/config.ini`, `p2/...`	Your own installer records. `config.ini` points back to the shared KNIME folder.

```
org.ovf.serverconnector,1.0.5.413,../../home/alice/.eclipse/1877637008_linux_gtk_x86_64/plugins/org.ovf.serverconnector_1.0.5.413.jar,4,false
```

Because this is a private copy of the list, it can go out of date. If an administrator changes KNIME, KNIME goes back to the shared list, which doesn't name your copy of the plugin. That is why a Just me install stops loading (section 8).

Settings: mostly in the workspace

The installer doesn't write any settings. The plugin writes them when KNIME runs:

File	What's in it
`<workspace>/.metadata/.plugins/org.eclipse.core.runtime/.settings/org.ovf.serverconnector.prefs`	**Your server list**, the active server, your choices about hiding prompts, and whether the tab has been placed and was open.
`<workspace>/.metadata/.plugins/org.eclipse.e4.workbench/workbench.xmi`	KNIME's saved window layout, which now includes the tab. This is how a KNIME without the plugin knows to show the red tab.

`<private area>/configuration/.settings/org.ovf.serverconnector.prefs`	Just me only: remembers that you've seen the one-time notice about a private install.

The workspace file after adding one server:

```
eclipse.preferences.version=1
serverconnector.activeServer=Test server
serverconnector.servers=[{"name"\:"Test server","url"\:"https\://server.example.com\:8443","allowSelfSigned"\:false,"type"\:"REMOTE"}]
serverconnector.viewOpenAtExit=true
serverconnector.viewPlaced=true
```

It holds a name, an address and two options for each server. The plugin has no password or login setting, so none is saved.

What doesn't change

- `knime.ini`, other extensions' files, and other KNIME folders.
- Any workspace, during the install. The settings above appear later, when KNIME opens that workspace.
- The Windows registry and environment variables: the installer has no code that touches them.

The permissions option is the one exception to "files only": `--apply-permissions` or `-ApplyPermissions` also changes who can access the files in the KNIME folder (section 7).

What removing it leaves behind

Removed	Left in place
The `bundles.info` line, so KNIME stops loading the plugin, and the `features/` folder.	The current version's jar in `plugins/`, unused until the plugin is installed again or KNIME's installer clears it. One record in `artifacts.xml`. Older versions' jars until the next change (section 10).
	Your workspace settings, including your server list, and the saved tab. If you install again, they come back as they were.

To remove every trace of a server list, delete `org.ovf.serverconnector.prefs` with KNIME closed.

These lists come from comparing every file before and after, on Linux with KNIME 4.1.3 and 5.8.1. On Windows, the jar, feature folder, `bundles.info` line and workspace settings file were confirmed at the same paths, but there was no full before-and-after comparison.